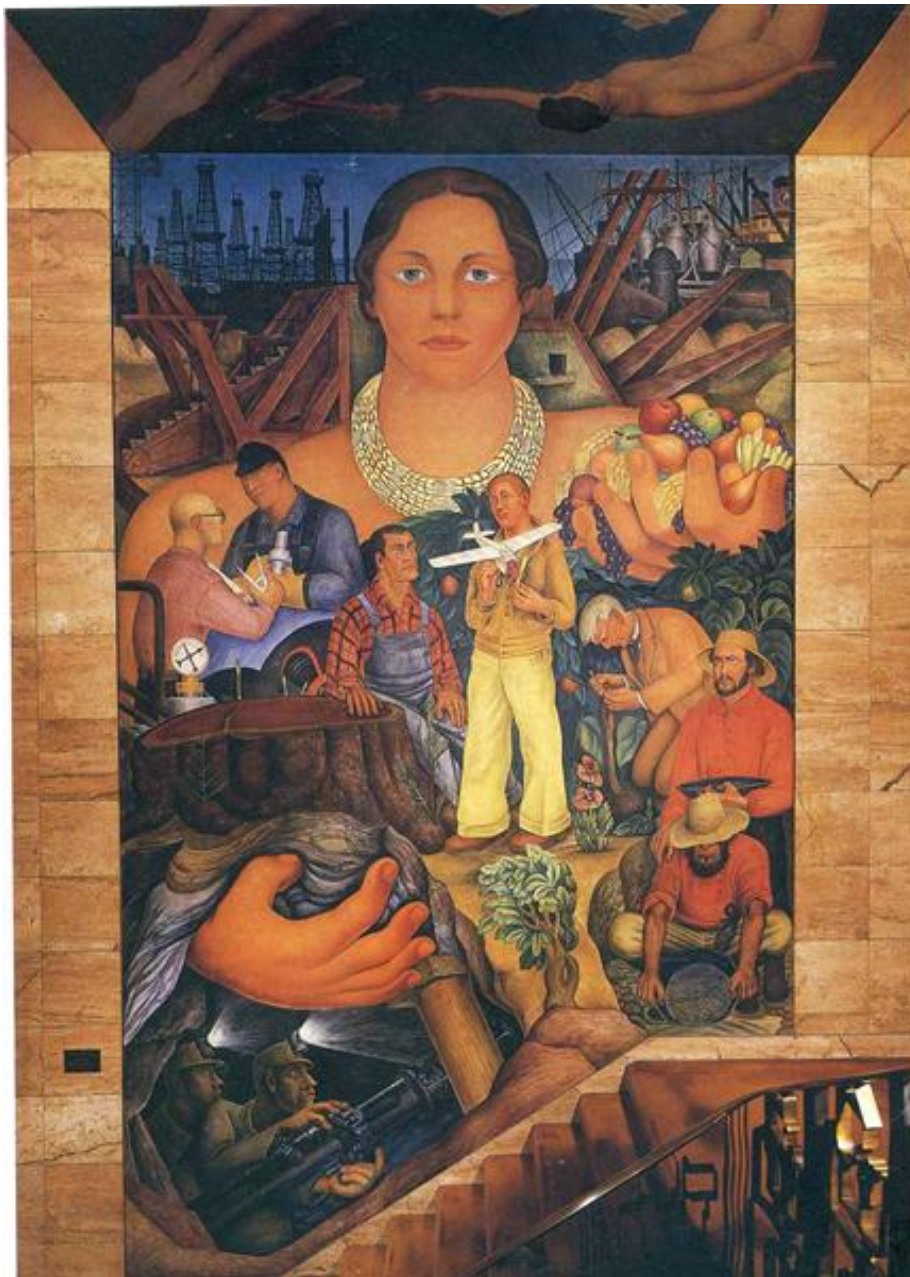


FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Worker Justice Sunday
August 31st, 2025



Allegory of California, Diego Rivera
1930-1931 San Francisco

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Nine Organ Frequencies (Improvisation in 9 x 3)

1st Tone: 175Hz (F3)
2nd Tone: 294Hz (D4)
3rd Tone: 392Hz (G4)
4th Tone: 415Hz (Ab4)
5th Tone: 523Hz (C5)
6th Tone: 622Hz (Eb5)
7th Tone: 740Hz (F#5)
8th Tone: 831Hz (Ab5)
9th Tone: 932Hz (Bb5)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Each Sunday as we gather,
our task in worship is no less than to dream
an impossible future
shaped by glimpses of a realm
of justice and life.

We are called here to boldly imagine
an impossible world
where what is broken is restored to wholeness
where the dead is brought to life.

In this place, we bring the world's most damaged realities
and hold them with faith that they will be changed
in the presence of hope and love.

Can you imagine a space more holy than this?

Welcome to this sacred time and space.

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

O For a World

AZMON

O for a world where everyone respects each other's ways,
where love is lived and all is done with justice and with praise.

O for a world where goods are shared and misery relieved,
Where truth is spoken, children spared, equality achieved.

We welcome one world family and struggle with each choice
That opens us to unity and gives our vision voice.

The poor are rich, the weak are strong, the foolish ones are wise.
Tell all who mourn, outcasts belong, who perishes will rise.

O for a world preparing for God's glorious reign of peace,
Where time and tears will be no more, and all but love will cease.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Fregin

Today, let us remember all those who, day-in and day-out,
give their labor to provide for all of us!
We remember the laborers who wake early,
We remember the laborers who work late,
We remember the laborers who have been wronged,
We remember the laborers afraid to leave their homes for work,
We remember the laborers who've been disappeared from their places of work,
We remember the laborers who are overlooked and denied dignity,
We remember the laborers who can't feed their children with their wages,
We remember the laborers who know they are working in the fields to feed us,
We remember the laborers who use their wages to raise their children
and care for their parents - whether they come from near or from far.

On this day, O God,
help each one of us to roll up our sleeves and to join all that labor
in our communities and across the world,
for together, we have work to do.

Then, O God, let us find you in all the work we share here and now,
as we follow the Way of Jesus, we pray.
Amen and Amen!

***Introit**

"Come Together"
Laude

TANNER PFEIFFER, arr. DAVID HARRIS

***The Lord's Prayer**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kindom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kindom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever. Amen.

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Each week during this time,
we remind each other that the peace of God
is constantly with us.
Today, we ask God's peace for each of us
as we work to embody the Way of Jesus
and to transform the injustices of our world.
And we ask that the peace of God will change
hearts and minds...including ours.

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you.

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition
From the Gospel of Matthew

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Tanaka Pack

The reign of God is like a landowner
who went out early in the morning to hire laborers for the vineyard.
After agreeing with the laborers for the usual daily wage,
the landowner sent them into his vineyard.

The owner went out about nine o'clock
and saw others standing idle in the marketplace; he said to them,
'You also go into the vineyard, and I will pay you whatever is right.'
So they went.

The owner went out again about noon and about three o'clock, and did the same.
And about five o'clock the owner went out
and found others standing around; and said to them,
'Why are you standing here idle all day?'

They said, 'Because no one has hired us'
to which the owner replied:
'You also go into the vineyard.'

When evening came, the owner of the vineyard said to the manager,
'Call the laborers and give them their pay,
beginning with the last and then going to the first.'

When those hired about five o'clock came,
each of them received the usual daily wage.

Now when the first came,
they thought they would receive more;
but each of them also received the usual daily wage.
And when they received it, they grumbled against the landowner, saying,
'These last worked only one hour,
and you have made them equal to us
who have borne the burden of the day and the scorching heat.'

But he replied to one of them,
'Friend, I am doing you no wrong;
did you not agree with me for the usual daily wage?
Take what belongs to you and go.
I choose to give to this last the same as I give to you.
Am I not allowed to do what I choose
with what belongs to me?
Or are you envious because I am generous?'

'Thus the last will be first and the first will be last.'

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Let justice roll down like waters,
and righteousness like an everflowing stream! [Amos 5:24]

The God of compassion thirsts for justice;
and gives us all the vision of God's way.

May this time of prayer help us to
share God's scandalous grace with all
in our midst, hold those suffering injustice in our hearts and minds,
and inspire us to co-creating with God a more just world for all.

*After the silence, you are invited to come forward to bring
your written prayers and to light candles to signify the prayers
of your hearts and pray for the life of the world.*

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Holy One, bless us with discomfort
at easy answers, half-truths, and superficial relationships
so that we may live from deep within our hearts.

*Bless us with anger
at injustice, oppression, and exploitation of your creation
so that we may work for justice, freedom, and peace.*

Bless us with tears
to shed for those who suffer pain, rejection, hunger, and war,
so that we may reach out our hands to comfort them and
to turn their pain into joy.

*And then, O God, bless us with just enough foolishness
to believe that we can make a difference in the world,
so that we can do what others claim cannot be done:
to bring justice and kindness to all our children and all our neighbors.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and amen.

Meditation Anthem

"Karitas habundat in omnia"
Cathedral Choir, Laurel Irene, Soloist

HILDEGARD VON BINGEN

*"Love abounds in all, from the depths exalted and excelling over every star,
and most beloved of all, for the most exalted dream, the kiss of peace she gave."*

Sermon

Sacred Worth, Sacred Work

Rev. Michael Lehman

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

*At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give.
Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.*

Offertory

"I Dream A World"
Cathedral Choir

ROSEPHANYE POWELL

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Rev. Fregin

*God of Justice,
your compassion and courage sustains us,
and your graciousness gives us hope.
Use us and these gifts to further your dream
as we co-create with you
a world filled with love, hope, peace, and justice.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Maybe in this time there has been a glimpse of the realm of God,
of what a community can be
that works for justice and equity.
Maybe it's a foretaste,
a hint,
a promise.
Let it hold you and let it send you
so you will never be at peace...

Until all are fed
Until all know home
Until all are free
Until justice is done
Until peace is the way
Until grace is the law
Until love is the rule.

Until God's realm comes
Until God's realm comes
Until God's realm comes
Amen and Amen!

Choral Response

"¡El Pueblo Unido!" SERGIO ORTEGA, arr. DAVID GARCÍA SALDAÑA

"Arise and sing that justice soon will ring. We raise the flag in solidarity, and you will join this march toward liberty where we'll be joined in new community! Our moment's arriving, the people are rising, their voices are growing, their anger's overflowing. The people united shall never be divided."

***Hymn for the Journey**

Let Justice Like Water

ST. DENIO

Let justice like waters roll down on our land;
Help us O Christ Jesus, to join in your plan.
Let righteousness like ever flowing streams rise;
Come, fill and anoint us, O Spirit most wise.

Pure wisdom and justice flow forth from your hand;
With you as our guide evil forces disband.
Give us, O Christ Jesus, the grace to prevail
O'er systems and powers that keep captives held.

O may we flow freely like waters and streams;
To heal and restore broken hearts and lost dreams.
Awaken us fully to all we can be,
Reclaiming our souls as we set people free.

Let justice like waters roll down on our land;
Help us O Christ Jesus, to join in your plan.
Let righteousness like ever flowing streams rise;
Come, fill and anoint us, O Spirit most wise.

[lyrics adapted from Jann Aldredge-Clanton]

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Hymn Improvisation

Inside The Music

"On September 20th, Laurel is singing a concert of Hildegard chant on the chancel as a part of the Golden Thread Concert Series. As she's been preparing, I've been stunned by the sheer beauty of the different pieces. I've known Hildegard's chants for a long time, and they always bring immediate and deep pause to me. That pause, and the prayer for peace that she offers in "Karitas", felt like what I needed to hear this week. In the midst of the national assault on workers rights that has been going on for decades, and is now at an apex, I found myself reflecting on Hildegard's life. She is by any measure one of the most prolific scholars, botanists, doctors, philosophers, theologians, poets, and musicians of her time. Yet, in her life, the only choice she had to explore these many gifts was through the cloister of the Cloth. I don't doubt that she loved being a nun, but am curious what her life might have been had these occupations been available to her in a real sense. The music has some fascinating elements. She wrote it in the dorian mode. Notably, she plays around with the raised and lowered 6th all in service of the interval of the 4th. To people who composed in modes, melodic sets of notes spoke in volumes to their dramatic sensibilities. This piece utilizes the interval and scale of the 4th in a persistent way. The scale build on the 4th was the more contained, prayerful, even undetermined musical set they used. Unlike many of her chants where she ranges through different types of scales, in this one, the vast majority of the piece centers around this contained, personal, nourishing 4th. The moments where another scalar element can be heard, a leap of a perfect 5th dominates the texture. The first two notes are such a leap, after which, melodic elements based on the 4th take over. This 5th leap feels like the kiss of peace. It is a bright light of promise from depths exalted, the response to which is self love. I love singing Rosephanye Powell's setting of Langston Hughes' "I Dream A World." Hughes, like Hildegard, was kept from opportunity. His influential poetry grew from a determination to live beyond the chances he was afforded in life. As Powell's music develops, it begins to churn like the American engine of the mid 20th-Century. As it churns, it wrestles with itself. Hughes' dream will not come easy. Yet, it is muscular and determined. It is a dream worth realizing, and one that, as we hear in the final chord, has an inevitability to it that breaks bonds and shatters injustice. Tanner joined Laude recently. I've loved their music for a while, and love singing "Come Together." From its folky spirit we hear a delightful turn of phrase: "and let us always, if we feel it, be extra in the ordinary." The struggle for worker justice is a struggle for the ordinary. It champions the passage of time; our hands employed in meaningful labor. To be extra in the ordinary, as Tanner encourages us, perhaps is merely to realize the simple magic of this prospect that everyone's labor is worth celebrating." – Dr. David Harris